Climate Justice and Resilient Communities learner guide

SWP-032 | Version 1.1.0 | SWEEP Academy

Use a rights-based, community-led approach to identify climate-related social inequities, strengthen adaptive capacity, and support accountable climate action within a professional role.

Use the laws, professional scope, organisational policies and approved referral routes that apply to your setting. This course is educational and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical or legal procedures. All worked cases are fictional. Research notes distinguish published findings from SWEEP teaching examples.

How to use this guide

Read each lesson, explain the worked example in your own words and complete its activity before checking the feedback. The decision points cover the concepts assessed; they are not a substitute for the explanations. Use the separate worksheet to integrate the three lessons. Study time depends on discussion and local adaptation, not a guaranteed completion duration.

Practice case

A riverside community is considering a raised meeting centre, drainage improvements and transport support during severe weather. Market traders worry about losing work during construction. People in outlying streets say previous planning meetings were difficult to attend. Compare options without assuming that one design benefits everyone equally.

Module 1 Climate risk inequity and rights

Distinguish a climate hazard from unequal exposure, vulnerability and capacity to respond.

Understand unequal risk and existing capacity

Separate the physical hazard from who or what is exposed and the conditions that affect people's ability to respond. A flood map can help locate exposure but does not reveal every barrier to evacuation, income security or access to care. Combine appropriate technical information with residents' accounts. Record the source, date and uncertainty of each statement. Do not attribute a particular event to climate change without suitable specialist evidence.

Map strengths alongside constraints: neighbours, local organisations, transport arrangements and knowledge can inform planning. Ask whose views are missing from meetings and offer accessible ways to contribute before choices are fixed. If relocation is discussed, investigate effects on livelihoods, services and relationships, as well as physical safety. Moving people is not in itself evidence that a fair or workable outcome has been achieved.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the project map shows two streets with similar flood exposure. Residents identify different transport access and work schedules. Planners record these differences and invite missing groups to discuss options rather than treating a single meeting as representative.

Decision points

A hazard map does not fully describe social risk: exposure, housing, livelihood dependence and capacity to respond can differ within the same area.

Do not describe communities only through deficits; identify local knowledge, mutual support and resources alongside constraints.

Displacement-related planning must consider access to livelihoods, services, relationships and meaningful participation; moving people is not itself proof of a just outcome.

Participation records should identify whose perspectives are missing, not equate attendance with representation.

Separate observed local impacts from explanations that need specialist evidence; avoid attributing every individual event to climate change without support.

Apply the lesson

Create a risk-and-capacity map in words for the riverside case. Separate observed information, resident accounts and questions requiring technical advice.

Check your reasoning

The map includes both capacities and barriers, missing voices and source uncertainty. It avoids unsupported event attribution and does not equate attendance with representation.

Module 2 Community led adaptation and resilient services

Compare adaptation options with communities, including accessibility, maintenance and unintended consequences.

Compare options over their whole life

Co-design requires room to change the proposal. Explain what decisions are still open, which constraints are real and who can authorise changes. Compare alternatives using agreed criteria such as accessibility, disruption, maintenance, responsible ownership and possible harm elsewhere. Do not reduce the comparison to initial cost or attendance at a consultation.

An option that protects one location can impose burdens on another. Ask who may lose access, time or income and seek technical advice about effects beyond the site. Consider the operating life: a facility without a workable maintenance plan may not remain useful. When resident experience and technical advice differ, document the difference and investigate it. Neither automatic dismissal of local knowledge nor unsupported rejection of expertise provides a sound decision.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: residents support the raised centre but identify an inaccessible approach route. The team revises the access design, checks its feasibility with qualified advisers and identifies responsibility for maintaining the route before treating the option as ready.

Decision points

Co-design begins while choices can still change; consultation after a fixed design offers limited influence.

An adaptation option may reduce one risk while shifting burdens elsewhere; assess who benefits and who may be harmed.

Accessible services need usable routes, communication and support; a nominal facility is not enough if intended users cannot reach or use it.

Compare adaptation options over their operating life, including responsibility and resources for upkeep.

Combine appropriate technical advice with community knowledge; conflicting accounts should prompt investigation rather than automatic dismissal.

Apply the lesson

Compare two options from the course case against access, burden distribution, upkeep and decision authority. State what evidence is still needed.

Check your reasoning

The comparison explains trade-offs and who bears them, includes operating responsibilities, and leaves unresolved technical questions open rather than inventing answers.

Module 3 Just transition advocacy and accountability

Assess how climate decisions distribute benefits and burdens and propose accountable follow-up.

Make distribution and follow up visible

A fair transition asks who gains and who loses access or livelihood as decisions change. Invite affected workers and communities to influence the response within clearly stated decision boundaries. Make commitments specific enough to follow: identify the responsible person, the action and a review point. An accessible complaint route also needs a responder and a way to learn whether concerns were addressed.

Monitor the distribution of benefits where collecting and reporting that information is safe and useful. A service-wide average can hide an excluded group, but small-group reporting can expose individuals. Use proportionate categories and protect confidential detail. Match advocacy claims to evidence and state uncertainty. If monitoring reveals new burdens, consult affected people and use the authorised adjustment process; avoid claiming success solely because construction or spending finished.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the centre opens, but traders report that the new route lengthens their journey. The project lead records the concern, checks it with affected users and technical advisers, and seeks approval for an adjustment. The public update explains what changed without naming complainants.

Decision points

A transition plan should examine who loses income or access as well as who gains; affected workers and communities need a meaningful role.

An accountability route needs accessible reporting, a responsible responder and a way to track responses without exposing complainants unnecessarily.

Disaggregate benefits where appropriate and safe: an average can hide who is not being reached.

Use evidence that matches the claim and acknowledge uncertainty when communicating with decision-makers.

Review an intervention when evidence shows new burdens; record the concern, consult affected people and use the authorised adjustment process.

Apply the lesson

Draft a short accountability plan: one benefit measure, one burden measure, a protected feedback route, an action owner and a review decision.

Check your reasoning

The plan can reveal uneven effects, protects complainants, assigns responsibility and explains when evidence would trigger a change.

Assessment preparation

Explain the reasons behind each decision point. Practise with the worksheet using a different situation from the worked examples. The proposed assessment has 15 single-answer questions and a 70% pass threshold, requiring at least 11 correct whole-mark answers. Published settings and availability must be verified in the learning platform; this guide does not establish an assessment ID or certify completion.

Sources and evidence limits

[R2] Cwikel, J. (2025). Social work for a greener planet: reframing social work skills and education to mitigate the climate crisis. Cogent Social Sciences. https://doi.org/10.1080/23311886.2024.2444469

Use in this course: A focused literature review discusses social-work skills and education for environmental challenges. Limit: Used for curricular relevance only, not evidence that a particular adaptation intervention works.

[S3] IPCC (2023). AR6 Synthesis Report Summary for Policymakers. https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/syr/summary-for-policymakers/

Use in this course: Assessment framework for climate risk and equitable responses. Limit: Not site-specific engineering advice or attribution of an individual local event.

[S4] IFSW (2018). Global Social Work Statement of Ethical Principles. https://www.ifsw.org/global-social-work-statement-of-ethical-principles/

Use in this course: Dignity, participation, confidentiality and professional accountability. Limit: Does not replace applicable law or organisational safeguarding procedures.

The index record is a discovery aid, not a guarantee of quality. Read the source before applying its findings to a different setting. No article endorses this course.